

# Andrea Ciccaraone

Columbia Business School, Columbia University  
665 W 130th St, New York, NY 10027  
[ac4790@columbia.edu](mailto:ac4790@columbia.edu) (646) 525-0556  
[andreaciccaraone.github.io](https://andreaciccaraone.github.io)

## Placement Chairs:

Mark Dean ([mark.dean@columbia.edu](mailto:mark.dean@columbia.edu))  
Martin Uribe ([mu2166@columbia.edu](mailto:mu2166@columbia.edu))

## Placement Administrators:

Jonathan Mendoza ([jam2546@columbia.edu](mailto:jam2546@columbia.edu))  
Amy Devine-Keum ([aed2152@columbia.edu](mailto:aed2152@columbia.edu))

## Education

---

|                                                                                                    |             |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <b>Columbia University</b><br>Ph.D. Candidate in Economics (BusEc track)                           | 2020 - 2026 |
| <b>Bocconi University</b><br>M.S. in Economics and Social Sciences, <i>110/110 Cum Laude</i>       | 2020        |
| <b>Bocconi University</b><br>B.S. in International Economics and Finance, <i>110/110 Cum Laude</i> | 2017        |

## Research Interests

---

Political Economy, Media Economics, Organizational Economics

## Job Market Paper

---

### An Image is Worth 1000 Words? Partisanship and Attention in Videos

*Abstract:* Political news today is increasingly consumed in attention-scarce, video-based environments. Yet existing research on media partisanship remains text-centric and implicitly assumes long-form, attentive processing. This paper studies how partisanship operates in video news through the transmission of multi-modal signals: images and text. I develop a multimodal measure of video partisanship to quantify partisan content in video news and decompose the contribution of each modality. I show that the informational strength of each modality depends on attention: images convey partisanship rapidly through affective cues, while text operates through substantive information that requires sustained exposure to accumulate. A survey experiment using real news footage shows how these properties shape viewers' responses to political videos. Partisan images elicit immediate emotional responses even under brief exposure, whereas partisan text shifts policy attitudes only with sustained exposure. Overall, the results show how low-attention video environments reshape persuasion, by filtering out substantive textual information, and relying mostly on the emotional effect of visual signals. Efforts to improve media quality must account for the asymmetric roles of visual and textual content.

## Working Papers

---

### The Mechanistic Fixed-Effects Topic Model: Recovering Corporate Culture from Employee Reviews

with [Dan Biderman](#), [David Blei](#), [Wei Cai](#), [Amir Feder](#) and [Andrea Prat](#)

*Abstract:* Social scientists use topic models to compare documents produced by different authors and in different contexts, even though the same broad topic may be expressed differently across environments. Existing methods usually control for this variation ex post and cannot separate common themes from environment-specific language. Their reliance on word counts also misses concepts conveyed through phrases, context, and tone. We introduce the mechanistic Fixed Effects Topic Model (mFETM), which embeds fixed effects

in the generative process and replaces word counts with interpretable concepts extracted from a large language model using sparse autoencoders (SAEs). Applied to a large corpus of Glassdoor reviews, mFETM recovers topics that are more stable across observed environments without sacrificing fit. At the firm level, mFETM recovers a broad, interpretable set of workplace dimensions associated with employer quality. A conventional model instead mixes these dimensions with environment-specific content, such as technology strategy, producing a narrower view of what distinguishes top employers. The removal exercise makes this difference visible: mFETM retains substantially more of its original fit when environment-associated topics are removed. Finally, the SAE representation lets us generate counterfactual reviews by steering along estimated fixed-effect directions, holding the topic fixed while changing its environment.

## **With or Without Conditions? Equity-Efficiency Tradeoffs in Municipal Transfers in Brazil**

with *Luigi Caloi*

*Abstract:* To improve service delivery, central governments can tie intergovernmental transfers to local policy performance. While performance-based transfers incentivize local governments and generate efficiency gains, they also shift transfers from low- to high-capacity governments, creating welfare-reducing inequities. We study this equity-efficiency trade-off using a bundle of transfer reforms to Brazilian municipalities. When two states tied transfers to relative educational performance, student test scores rose substantially: moving from the 25th to the 75th percentile of per capita conditional transfers increased scores by 0.16 standard deviations. However, the reform also widened funding disparities across municipalities, which translated into disparities in municipal expenditures in multiple sectors. In contrast, contemporaneous reforms to unconditional transfers had negligible effects on student outcomes. We use a simple model of optimal transfers to interpret these findings. Our results suggest that the introduction of performance based transfers delivered large efficiency gains, limited welfare losses from inequities, and was welfare-enhancing. We find minimal evidence of multitasking distortions or score manipulation. Instead, we document improvements in the quality of education inputs and find suggestive evidence of reduced corruption.

## **Awards, Fellowships, and Grants**

---

|                                                                                      |                |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| CPE Graduate Student Grant Opportunity, <i>Columbia Center for Political Economy</i> | 2024           |
| CELSS Seed Grant, <i>Columbia Experimental Laboratory in the Social Sciences</i>     | 2024           |
| J-PAL's Jobs and Opportunity Initiative Brazil (with Luigi Caloi), <i>J-PAL</i>      | 2023           |
| Wueller Fellowship for Best Teaching Fellow (Runner-up), <i>Columbia University</i>  | 2022           |
| Dean's Fellowship, <i>Columbia University</i>                                        | 2020 – Present |

## **Seminars & Conferences**

---

|                                                              |      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| IUG-BFI Spring Conference, Economics of Media Bias Workshop, | 2026 |
| Bocconi AI and Society Conference, CEPR Media Workshop       |      |
| AI+Economics Workshop Zurich                                 | 2025 |

## **Other Research Experience**

---

|                                                                                             |           |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Research Assistant to Prof. Andrea Prat and Andrey Simonov, <i>Columbia Business School</i> | 2021–2024 |
| Research Assistant to Prof. Cailin Slattey, <i>Columbia Business School</i>                 | 2021–2022 |
| Research Assistant to Prof. Thomas Le Barbanchon, Bocconi University                        | 2019–2020 |
| Research Assistant to Prof. Marco Ottaviani, Bocconi University                             | 2019–2020 |

## **Teaching Experience**

---

|                                                              |             |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Main Instructor in Math Camp (Economics MA)                  | 2022 – 2024 |
| Guest Lecturer in Political Economy (PhD), Prof. Andrea Prat | 2022 – 2024 |
| TA in Industrial Organization (MA), Prof. Ildikó Magyari     | 2024        |

|                                                            |             |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| TA in Game Theory and Business (MBA), Prof. Andrea Prat    | 2022 – 2024 |
| TA in Corporate Finance (UG), Prof. Tri Vi Dang            | 2023        |
| TA in Math Methods for Economists (MA), Prof. Isaac Bjorke | 2022        |

## Academic Service

---

Referee: *Economica*, *Economic Journal*

## Bio

---

Citizenship: Italian  
Gender: Male

## References

---

### Andrea Prat

Professor of Economics & Business  
Columbia University  
[andrea.prat@columbia.edu](mailto:andrea.prat@columbia.edu)

### Suresh Naidu

Professor of Economics &  
International and Public Affairs  
Columbia University  
[sn2430@columbia.edu](mailto:sn2430@columbia.edu)

### Mark Dean

Professor of Economics  
Columbia University  
[mark.dean@columbia.edu](mailto:mark.dean@columbia.edu)